Chapter Thirty-Two

The First Delhi Sultanate

Between 1206 and 1236,
the Muslim kingdom in northern India
asserts itself against Hindus,
but cannot survive the leadership of a woman

In 1202, the Muslim Ghurids had advanced into the Ganges valley, pushing the Sena into oblivion, welcomed by the people who had found the strict Hinduism of the Sena kings distasteful. The Ghurid sultan, Ghiyas ad-Din Ghuri, had only months to cherish his victory. He died of a sudden illness in Herat, back west of the Himalayas, leaving his brother Muhammad at the head of the brand-new Ghurid empire.

Muhammad Ghuri, deputized by Ghiyas to rule the Indian territories, had always been loyal to his older brother; now he was rewarded with the Ghurid crown. This was not good news for Ghiyas's son Mahmud, who had expected to take over his father's throne. Instead, Muhammad made his nephew deputy ruler of the western territories only. Mahmud was known for his love of wine and women, not for his skill as a governor, and Muhammad Ghuri was inclined to reward talent over blood. He had no children. Instead, the *Tabakat-i-Nasiri* tells us, he "purchased a number of Turkish slaves, and greatly valued them all, and raised them to competence and wealth." Those slaves who served him well as soldiers were rewarded with deputy governorships of their